

BUILT FOR MORE

THE FIRST RESPONDER RETIREMENT CHECKLIST

The 21 things to know before you count on your pension.

Fire · Police · EMS · Corrections · Dispatch

01 — KNOW YOUR PENSION

☐ Find your multiplier

The % per year of service. It's in your pension handbook or member portal. This single number drives everything.

☐ Know your FAS window

Final Average Salary — how many years (3? 5?) and whether OT counts. This decides how your last years on the job get valued.

☐ Confirm your vesting date

The date your pension becomes yours even if you leave. Write it down.

☐ Run your actual number

Multiplier x years x FAS. Most people guess. Ten minutes ends the guessing.

☐ Check the COLA

Does your pension adjust for inflation? Fixed, capped, or none — it changes what your check buys at 70.

☐ Read the survivor options

What your spouse gets if you go first. These elections are usually permanent — never pick blind.

02 — YOUR ACCOUNTS

☐ Confirm you're enrolled in the 457(b)

If your employer offers one and you're not in it, that's this week's fix.

☐ Know what you contribute

The dollar amount, per paycheck. If it hasn't changed since you enrolled, it's probably too low.

☐ Check your fund's expense ratio

Inside your 457(b), what does your fund cost? Under ~0.2% is good. Over 1% is quietly eating years of growth.

☐ Open (or fund) a Roth IRA

Tax-free growth on top of a taxable pension is a powerful combination.

☐ Hunt down old accounts

Prior jobs, old 401(k)s, forgotten IRAs. Consolidate so your money has one address.

03 — PROTECT YOUR FAMILY

- ☐ **Update every beneficiary**
Pension, 457(b), life insurance, bank accounts. Especially after a marriage, divorce, or birth.
- ☐ **Check your life insurance**
The job's policy usually isn't enough for a young family. Price level term — it's cheaper than you think.
- ☐ **Write the one-pager**
One page: accounts, passwords location, contacts, what to do first. Your spouse should never have to dig through drawers on the worst day.
- ☐ **Get a basic will done**
Uncomfortable for a week, protective for decades. If you have kids, this is not optional.
- ☐ **Have the money talk**
Your spouse should know what exists and where — before it matters.

04 — THE GAPS

- ☐ **Plan for health insurance before 65**
Retiring at 52 leaves a 13-year gap before Medicare. Know what your department, union, or VEBA covers — and what it costs.
- ☐ **Build the emergency fund**
3-6 months of expenses. Injuries and light duty are real in this line of work.
- ☐ **Learn your DROP rules**
If your system has DROP: when you're eligible, how long it runs, and what entering early really costs you.
- ☐ **Pull your Social Security estimate**
ssa.gov, ten minutes. Know what's actually there and how your pension interacts with it under current law.
- ☐ **Set a debt-free date**
The cheapest retirement is one without payments. Know when your last debt dies — and whether it beats your badge-off date.

THIS MONTH: PICK THREE BOXES.

Not all 21. Three. Progress beats perfection — and next month, pick three more.

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